



RAIDERS FROM THE SEA

Late in the eighth century a seafaring people from the countries now known as Denmark, Norway, and Sweden began to sail abroad in search of wealth. They were called Vikings. In their amazingly fast and adaptable longships, Vikings were the best sailors in Europe. They began by raiding foreign lands, and went on to conquer and settle there. They were also great sea traders. Many of the Vikings became Christians. It was the Vikings who founded the cities of Dublin in Ireland and Kiev in Ukraine. The Normans were descended from Viking settlers in northern France.

The mast supported a big square sail. This was used when the longship was out at sea and there was plenty of wind to fill the sail.

Longships were called "Serpents of the Sea." They were decorated with scary animal carvings called figureheads.

As Vikings prepare to land on a foreign shore, warriors stand at the front of the longship, with settlers in the middle.

